



2023 haunt her? Her 2-6, 6-3, 6-2 defeat to Gauff — after leading the American teenager 6-2, 2-0 — left Sabalenka in tears and so angry that she smashed her rackets on the locker room floor.

Pegula experienced much less drama during her tennis career, but tragedy also struck the 30-year-old Buffalo, New York native two years ago when her mother Kim suffered a stroke that left her with brain damage and memory loss.

"My mom loved to work. She did everything, and our family constantly told her how she needs to slow down and take time for herself," Pegula wrote in a poignant first-person post for *Players Tribune* in February 2023.

"She gave everyone so much of her time and effort. She lived it and loved it, and it was felt by everyone she met. Now we come to the

realisation that all of that is most likely gone. That she won't be able to be that person anymore."

Pegula made six Grand Slam quarterfinals from 2021-23 and lost all of them. Time wasn't on her side, and sensing that her results had plateaued, she split with her longtime coach David Witt and hired Mark Merklein and Mark Knowles, a former doubles No. 1.

Despite second-round defeats at the Australian Open and Wimbledon, the gamble paid off. On the summer hard-court circuit, she won the Toronto tournament and defeated resurgent standouts Karolina Muchova and Paula Badosa to make the Cincinnati final.

While the first semifinal saw Sabalenka overcome Emma Navarro in a close contest, the other semifinal pitted Pegula, the super-solid

stroker, against Muchova, the super athlete. One of the greatest "What ifs?" of this century is: what if the immensely talented 28-year-old Czech had not been plagued so often by serious injuries that derailed her career?

For a recent example, Muchova nearly upset Swiatek, the Queen of Clay, in the 2023 French Open final only to be sidelined for around ten months before and after a wrist surgery in February.

At Flushing Meadows, the lithe, 5'11" Muchova reached the semis without dropping a set. Her most impressive win came when she outclassed No. 5 seed and surprise French and Wimbledon finalist Jasmine Paolini 6-3, 6-3.

"I couldn't be more happy that I'm here," said Muchova, who played only 12 matches this year,